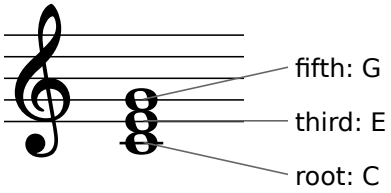
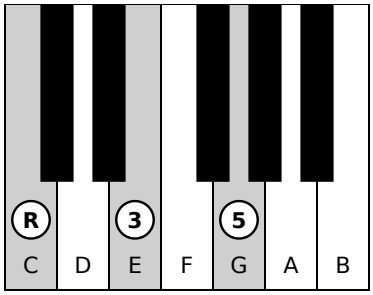
Triads

A **chord** is three or more notes sounded together. A **triad** is a three-note chord built from two 3rds stacked one on top of the other. The lowest note of the stack is the **root**, the note a 3rd above it is the **third**, and the note a 5th above the root is the **fifth**. A triad is named for its root: C, E, and G form a C triad.





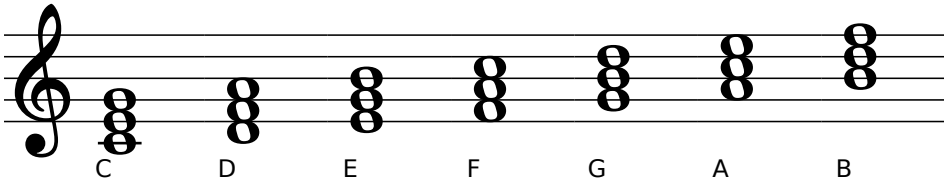
R = root, 3 = third, 5 = fifth

Root position

A triad is in **root position** when the root is the lowest note. On the staff, a root-position triad has all three notes on lines or all three in spaces, each note directly above the one below it. Later chapters cover triads with the third or fifth at the bottom.

Triads on every scale note

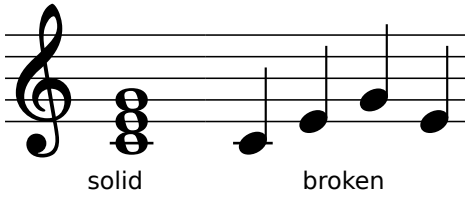
A triad can be built on each note of a scale, using only the notes of that scale. In C major, the seven triads use only white keys:



Root-position triads on each note of the C major scale, named by root.

Solid and broken triads

Played together, the notes form a **solid** (or blocked) triad. Played one at a time, they form a **broken** triad. Both are named the same way.



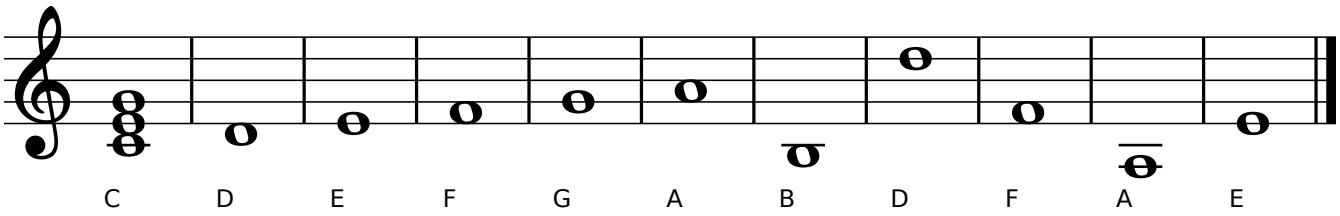
© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.

Name _____ Date _____

Building Triads

A. Complete the triads Add the third and the fifth above each root to make a root-position triad. Use letter names only.

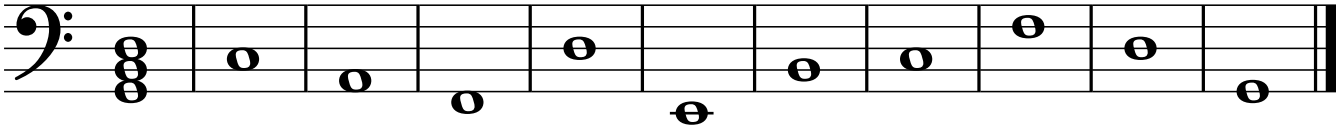
EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5. 6. 7. 8. 9. 10.



C D E F G A B D F A E

B. Complete the triads in the bass clef Add the third and the fifth above each root.

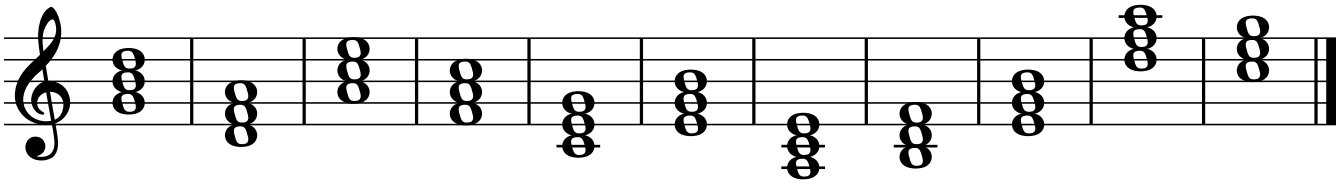
EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5. 6. 7. 8. 9. 10.



G C A F D E B C F D G

C. Name the root Write the letter name of the root of each root-position triad.

EXAMPLE 1. 2. 3. 4. 5. 6. 7. 8. 9. 10.



G _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____

© 2026 Matthew Menard. All rights reserved.